Although my grades were higher than average, my principal academic ambition at Eureka was to maintain the C average I needed to remain eligible for football, swimming, track, and the other school activities I participated in—two years in the student senate, three years as basketball cheerleader, three years as president of the Eureka Boosters Club, two years as yearbook features editor, and, during my last year, student body president and captain and coach of the swim team.

Despite my preoccupation with extracurricular activities, I'm convinced I got a solid liberal arts education at Eureka, especially in economics. It was a major I chose because I thought, one way or another, I'd end up dealing with dollars, if not at my father's store, in some other business.

As 1930 began, the full contours of the Depression were becoming apparent and one of its first casualties was my father's grandest dream.

In Dixon, troubles in the farming economy had begun months before the crash and when the full force of the Depression struck, it hit our town like a cyclone: The price of milk dropped to a level so low that it didn't pay farmers to milk their cows anymore; hundreds of people were out of work; the cement plant slashed its work force, then closed down; one by one, like streetlights flickering off at daybreak, many of the most prestigious stores in Dixon closed.

One of them was the Fashion Boot Shop.

In a city where few people could afford a new pair of shoes, Mr. Pitney, his wealth depleted by the crash, had to close my father's store, and with it Jack's only chance of ever owning his own store.

The Depression had such an oppressive effect that it cast a dreary pall over everything. But there was a small beacon of light amid the misery: Like any shared calamity, the Depression brought people closer together in marvelous ways. There was a spirit of warmth and helpfulness and,